

Charlotte Bronte's *Jane Eyre*

The Victorian age

- From Queen Victoria's accession in 1837 to her death 1901
- Seen as a period of peace, prosperity, and self-confidence for England
- Rapid economic & social changes
- Rise of industrial capitalism (commerce, manufacturing) & imperialism
- The Age of Empire: the largest empire in history (Canada, India, Australia, much of Africa and the Caribbean..)
- Establishment of middle-class & the ideological function of the novel: the novel helps to redefine relations between different classes & men/women
- "The Woman Question"
 - Domestic ideology; "the Angel in the House"; 'separate spheres' of men/women

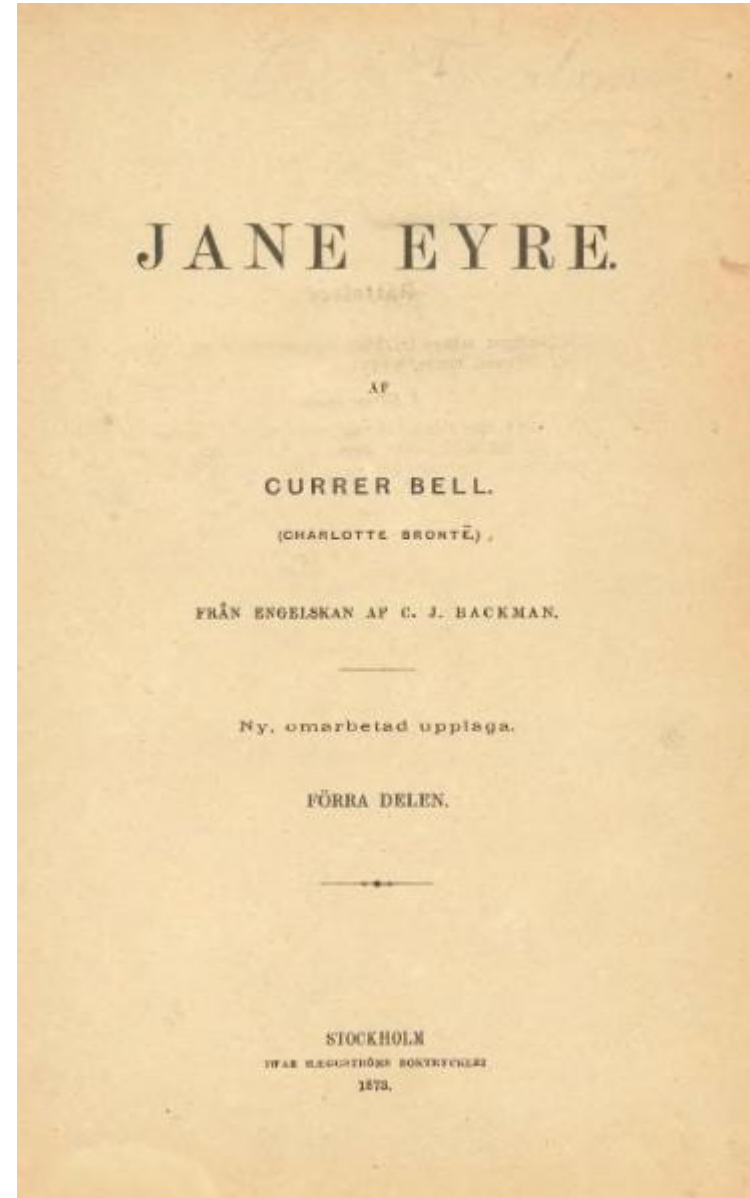
Charlotte Bronte

- Born 1816 as third child to Patrick Bronte, a clergyman
- Mother died early
- Two older sisters died from illnesses from caught from girl's school
- Younger sisters Emily, Anne & brother Branwell
- Teaching , either as teachers or as a governess, was the only profession open to the average middle-class women
- Bronte girls tried to make money by opening girls' school but failed



- Instant success of *Jane Eyre* (1847)
- written under pseudonym Currer Bell
- "Literature cannot be the business of a woman's life, and it ought not to be. The more she is engaged in her proper duties, the less leisure will she have for it, seen as an accomplishment and a recreation"

-advise from Robert Southey, the poet laureate to Bronte



Bronte's explanation of the pseudonym

- "Averse to personal publicity, we veiled our own names under those of Currer, Ellis and Acton Bell; the ambiguous choice being dictated by a sort of conscientious scruple at assuming Christian names positively masculine, while we did not like to declare ourselves women, because — without at that time suspecting that our mode of writing and thinking was not what is called 'feminine' — we had a vague impression that authoresses are liable to be looked on with prejudice"

Mixture of Genres for Jane Eyre

1) Autobiography: a narrative account written by an individual to depict one's life and character

2) Romance: fictional work that contains adventure, thwarted love, mysterious circumstances, and improbable triumphs
-Rejects realistic verisimilitude in favor of fanciful or fantastic depictions

3) Bildungsroman: a story about character's development

- How does a woman change? How does she reconcile with the norms of the society?
- a "novel of education" "novel of formation" a novel which traces the spiritual, moral, psychological or social development and growth of the main character from (usually) childhood to maturity

Mixture of Genres

- 4) **Gothic**: utilizes the mysterious, the supernatural, the horrific
-atmosphere of suspense and fear
- Typically characterized by a general mood of decay, dramatic and even violent actions, gloomy settings and atmosphere of terror
- They often externalize Victorian fears about the “foreign,” the unknown, and the uncontrollable.
- By linking the supernatural with racialized otherness, the Gothic becomes a vehicle for expressing anxieties about race and empire
- **Female Gothic** – a tradition of Gothic writing by women that represents the female experience within domesticity as one of imprisonment, claustrophobia, and terror
- Gothic elements allow female authors to express their criticism towards women’s position in Victorian society

- What do you know about Bertha in *Jane Eyre*?
- How is Bertha described in *Jane Eyre*?
- What narrative perspective shapes our understanding of her?
- What is missing from Bertha's story?
- How does the novel use her to develop Jane's identity?

Jane as a Narrator

- What kind of a narrator is she?
- First person narrative
- Direct, plain, open
- Trustworthy but unreliable
- Speaking empowers her “Speak I must” (51)

Jane as a character

- Small & plain (not a typical beautiful heroine of a romance)
- Unhappy and suffering
- Outcast and alienated due to her status and disposition
- "heterogeneous" (20) Jane as an orphan "you are a dependent...you have no money" (11) "less right to be here than a servant" (32)
- Inferior & oppressed by John Reed "tyrant" "murderer"
- Angry, rebellious, with powerful sense of her injustice
- -talks back; fights back at John Reed
- Passionate, emotional, imaginative but her passion is seen as unnatural, violent and dangerous

Themes in Jane Eyre

1) Gender & Patriarchy

- Jane's struggle for autonomy
- Rochester's power and control

2) Morality & Desire

- Jane's internal conflict between passion and principle
- Victorian ideals of purity, restraint, and self-discipline

3) Class & Social Mobility

- Jane's inferior social standing "dependent"
- Wealthy upper-class gentry vs lower, working class; master vs slave
- Governess as liminal class position

Mr. Rochester and Thornfield

- Jane applies for the governess job after she finishes her education at Lowood school
- Mysteries surrounding Mr. Rochester "good master" but "peculiar" (162)
- Gothic setting – a typical haunted house with ancient, strange rooms, dark corridors, mysterious mood "ghost at Thornfield Hall" (161)
- Associated with "violent" family history, ghosts, "Bluebeard's castle" (162) , eerie laugh by Grace "a curious laugh" "tragic, as preternatural a laugh as any I ever heard" (164)

Chapter 12

- Generally seen as Bronte's feminist manifesto
- Jane's desire for independence & liberty
- "discontented..restlessness was in my nature... life, fire, feeling"
- "It is in vain to say human beings ought to be satisfied with tranquility..."
- Suggests a political rebellion of the oppressed (class, race, gender etc)
- "Women are supposed to be very calm generally..."
- Sharp criticism of rigid Victorian gender roles (Angel of the House) => accompanied with Grace's laughter

Jane's first encounter with Mr. Rochester

- Bronte blends the Gothic style with realism
- Romantic, magical, fairytale-like setting
- Although she is his social inferior, she is the one to give help to a "master in a predicament" (172) in their first meeting
- She offers help to him in their first meeting –her deed is an "active thing" (176)
- Stranger - "masculine...dark, strong, stern" (173)
- Mrs. Fairfax provides Rochester's "family troubles" – his inheritance and making his fortune (194)
- He envies Jane's youth and innocence "I might have been as good as you" (206)
- He confesses he became a sinner due to circumstances & fate "I turned desperate; then I degenerated" (207)

Fire incident

- Jane hears a "demoniac laugh" (225) & puts out fire from Mr. Rochester's room
- Another incident of Jane's being useful to Mr. Rochester (& Mr. Rochester's emotional response "you have saved my life" (230)
- Jane is puzzled at how Grace is treated at Thornfield "from that participation in that mystery, I was purposely excluded" (250)
- Jane's frank & powerful declaration of love for Mr. Rochester- the moment Jane sees Mr. Rochester again, she confesses "I had not intended to love him" "He made me love him.. I believe he is of mine... I must love him" (132)

Cha 20 Mr. Mason

- Blanche and other ladies and gentlemen are invited to the party at Thornfield
- Mr. Mason's arrival - "still not altogether English" "he repelled me exceedingly" (289)
- "savage" cry in the night, Mr. Mason's stabbing (312)
- "Am I wanted?" (315) Jane again offers help & keeps her promise
- "wild beast or the fiend" "mocking demon... bird of prey (320), "tigress" "she sucked the blood" (323)
- Relationship between Mr. Mason & Mr. Rochester

Cha 23 - The Proposal

- Jane's assertion of equality & individualism - "Do you think I am an automaton" – a machine without feelings? Do you think, because I am poor, obscure, plain, and little, I am soulless and heartless?... We stood at God's feet, equal – as we are!" (386)
- "I am a free human being with an independent will" (386)
- Rochester then proposes to Jane : "my equal is here, and my likeness Jane. Will you marry me? " (387)
- Chestnut tree is struck by lightning - foreshadowing

Cha 25 Courtship and Jane's dream

- During courtship, Rochester takes Jane shopping "the more he bought me, the more my cheek burned with a sense of annoyance and degradation" (409)
- Jane is humiliated and refuses to being reduced to a powerless sex slave
"I will not be your English Celine Varens" (411)
- Jane's nightmare before the wedding - a woman with "savage face", the "Vampyre" (432) destroys Jane's veil
- Rochester's secrecy "when we are married a year and a day, I will tell you;" (434)
- How is Bertha related to Jane? Similarities or differences?
- Bertha can be seen as Jane's foil and dark double
- Her ripping of the marriage veil can be seen as her rage against oppressive gender norms & resistance to patriarchy
- Bertha embodies the anger desire, and rebellion that Jane must suppress to remain socially acceptable
- She represents a consequence of female passion without restraint

Cha 26 Wedding

- Wedding is halted by Mr. Briggs and Mr. Mason "an insuperable impediment to this marriage exists" (441)
- Mr. Rochester's bigamy & "disgusting secret" (445)
- His description of Bertha and his representation of his troubled past
- Bertha Mason: Creole, used to be beautiful, coming from "a mad family", now kept in secret (445)
- Rochester's treatment of Bertha mirrors the logic of empire: domination, confinement, and the erasure of the colonized subject's voice
- He controls her physically and controls her narrative by defining her as "mad"
- He justifies oppression by portraying colonized as irrational or inferior

Rochester's control over Bertha and justification

- Jane is disappointed that Rochester was false and that her feeling for him was only "fitful passion" (451)
- Rochester defends himself by telling about his marriage (464)
- Bertha's "violent and unreasonable temper" ; "her vices sprang up fast and rank" ; "her excesses had prematurely developed the germs of insanity" ; "monster" ; "the lunatic is both cunning and malignant" (466)
- Rochester's self-hatred, sexual lust, rivalry
- Bertha's existence exposes his hypocrisy and moral contradictions
- While he presents himself as a victim of deceptive marriage, his actions (imprisoning, manipulating) undermine his credibility

Self & Other (racial)

- Rochester's representation of Bertha and his life with her : a white, male gaze on the female, colonized
- Bertha is seen as not only mad but everything bad (Rochester making Bertha the 'other')
- She is described using racialized, animalistic imagery reflecting Victorian fears of racial "otherness"
- Her Creole appearance is seen as less than human - projection of stereotype and racism
- This portrayal reinforces stereotypes about Creole identity as unstable or dangerous
 - le) madness & family heredity (excess of alcoholism), beastlike, cunning, uncontrollable passion, insanity, needing to be restrained
- Binary between the colony (the West Indies) vs. the old world (England, Europe) : "one night..." (469)
- Rochester's efforts to find "a contrast to the fury I left at Thornfield," "the antipodes of the Creole" (474)

Chap 36 Jane's journey home and the fire

- After reuniting with her cousins and receiving her inheritance, Jane hears Rochester's voice calling her and returns to Thornfield
- Jane finds out Bertha has set fire and killed herself (652)
- The fire symbolizes the destruction of the oppressive structure that confined her, but it also clears the way for Jane and Rochester's eventual reunion
- Rochester's courageous actions during the fire – tries to save Bertha - ends up "helpless...blind and a cripple" (655)
- The fire is punishment - he is destroyed by his unrestrained passion - "just judgment" (654)
- The fire is also redemptive – he is purged of sin and restored – he undergoes true repentance & turns to God

Imperialism/Colonialism

- British Imperialism in *Jane Eyre* – characters' wealth & independence are dependent on resources of empire & economic exploitation
- Mr. Rochester's initial wealth comes from Bertha, or the Caribbean plantation economies
- So English estate at Thornfield is literally funded by colonial exploitation
- It is implied that John Eyre, Jane's uncle, also gets fortune from business in colony (Madeira)

Why Bertha matters

- 1) A **plot device** (the Gothic secret, the obstacle to marriage)
- 2) A **symbol** (repressed female anger, the “dark double” of Jane)
 - Confinement of Victorian wifhood -insanity due to isolation and imprisonment
 - Jane’s double, a projection of criminal self – rage, aggression – but scapegoated and punished
- 3) A **racialized, colonial figure** (a Creole woman from Jamaica)
 - Bertha, a Creole in British colony, functions as the scapegoat in the narrative and also as a medium for the *Bildung* of Jane, a white female
 - Her imprisonment in the attic symbolizes the repression of imperial history, its hidden violence and exploitation
 - Her confinement suggests British anxieties about colonies & the need to control them

- Bertha is a **silenced character** (she never speaks for herself)
- all information about her comes through Rochester or Jane.
- This silence reflects how marginalized, racialized women were denied narrative agency in Victorian literature.

What if we attempt to perceive the situation from Bertha Mason's perspective?